

Q Is it safe to have sex now that I'm pregnant, or could it harm the baby or even break my water?

It is safe to have sex in a straight forward pregnancy. It won't harm your baby as he is well cushioned in his amniotic sac and research has shown that it's highly unlikely that penetration can rupture your membranes and cause your water to break.

The biggest challenge to having intercourse when you're pregnant is accommodating your growing abdomen, but there's no health reason why you should stop having sex. In fact, later in pregnancy, the uterine contractions of an orgasm can help prepare you for birth. Many couples enjoy the freedom of having sex without using any contraception or without having to give thought to the consequences. However, remember that you can still contract sexually transmitted diseases, so if this is a concern use a condom.

Although sex is safe for your baby, it might not be all that comfortable for you, due to breast tenderness, cramping, nausea or increased fatigue. You might find gentle lovemaking more comfortable and you may need to adapt or experiment with different positions at various stages of your pregnancy. Many couples report that a side position works best of all, either facing or in spooning position with your partner behind you.

Many women experience swings in their sex drive during pregnancy. You may feel more sensitive due to the increased blood flow to the breasts and vagina, and the rise in progesterone and estrogen in your body, which can increase your libido. Your changing body might be incredibly exciting to your partner, or he might be too fearful of hurting

the baby to relax. If you don't want to have sex, find other ways of being intimate with your partner. Communication and touching are essential for keeping you close and connected as a couple. For many couples the knowledge that they have created a life together helps to enhance their lovemaking.



Take time to rest together By cuddling you can feel connected with your partner. Take a nap together or just have a lazy afternoon relaxing.

WHEN TO AVOID SEX

There are a few cases where it is best to avoid penetrative sex and your doctor may advise it for some medical situations. If you have any signs of infection, such as an unusual discharge, itchiness, or pain when you have sex, consult your doctor.

» **Bleeding:** If you've had any heavy bleeding during pregnancy, there may be an increase in the risk of more bleeding.

» **Previous miscarriages** or premature births.

» **Water has broken:** Once this happens, sex could introduce infection.

» **Cervical insufficiency** (see p.147)

» **Placenta previa** (see p.147)



Did you know...

Later in pregnancy, an orgasm can set off Braxton Hicks contractions (see p.201). Don't worry—this is a fairly common occurrence but if you're uncomfortable, try slow, deep breathing or relaxation techniques until they pass.

Q I'm worried about radiation harming my baby. Can I still use my cell phone or microwave?

There is no evidence to suggest you should stop using your cell phone—or microwave—during pregnancy. Studies into the long-term effects of cell phones on our health (whether we're pregnant or not) are still in their infancy, so for the time being, it's impossible to be definitive about possible hazards. Cell phones send out radio waves, just like (and no more dangerous than) the waves that come from your

computer or your television. People worry more about phones because we hold them against our heads while we're using them. If you keep yours in a pocket close to your abdomen when you're not using it, from current evidence there's no danger to your baby. But if you're worried, carry your cell phone in your handbag or breast pocket and when you talk, use speakerphone and hold the phone away from your body.

Modern microwave ovens are built to strict guidelines that ensure any radiation "leakage" falls well below levels known to harm humans. If you're pregnant and you use a microwave, make sure it's up to modern safety standards. Stand back while the microwave is in operation.

Q Can I have a dental X-ray while I'm pregnant?

Most dental X-rays are too short, far enough away from your abdomen, and of low enough strength to be perfectly safe during pregnancy.

However, make sure you tell your dentist you're pregnant so that he or she can advise you. Similarly, most chest and limb X-rays are safe during pregnancy. In almost all cases, if your doctor thinks you need to have an X-ray despite your pregnancy, it's because the benefits of doing so far outweigh the risks to you and your baby.